ment of the home secretary as well.

As expected, the changes have not gone down well with any of the political parties—except for the BJP. Even parties alleged to be allies/proxies of the saffron party are up in arms, calling for a "united strategy" to oppose the diminished state being envisaged. Syed Altaf Bukhari, chief of the Apni Party, for instance, is said to have New Delhi's blessings, having been the first to launch a political outfit post-370, in 2021. But the businessman-turned-neta is livid. "They want the chief minister to be a toothless tiger and fool the people," he says, urging his rivals to shun political differences and prepare for a joint struggle. "If we can't stand united today, then we will never be able to. We should ensure that the statehood we get is not hollow."

National Conference leader Hasnain Masoodi, a former MP and J&K High Court judge, also questions the Modi-led government's intentions. "The change in business rules is less legal and more political," says Masoodi. "It tells us that the Centre intends to prolong its rule by proxy. With no public mandate, the L-G will have the power to make all the decisions. This is against the spirit of democracy." Party leader and former chief minister Omar Abdullah tweeted that "the people deserve better than a powerless, rubber stamp CM who will have to beg the L-G to get his/her peon appointed". Back in Delhi, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge called it "another example of the '*samvidhan hatya* (murder of the Constitution)' happening daily under the Modi government".

THE NEW RULES

- **MHA amends 'transaction of business' rules pertaining to the J&K Reorganisation Act, 2019**
- **Transfer/posting of IAS/IPS officers, rules regarding police, public order, land no longer need concurrence from state finance department, L-G's discretion final**
- **Elected J&K govt also loses powers to appoint advocate-general**
- **All matters related to prisons, directorate of prosecution, forensic science lab with L-G**
- **L-G to have say on grant of prosecution sanction**



NOWHERE TO GO Security cordon in Srinagar

AP

The amendments have indeed cast a long shadow, especially since they come less than a month after the announcements Prime Minister Narendra Modi made during his visit to Srinagar. The PM had raised hopes by promising the restoration of statehood and holding of the long-overdue assembly election. Former J&K law secretary Ashraf Mir, though, is not surprised. "The amendments align with the J&K Reorganisation Act," he says. "They (the Centre) have clearly delineated powers before installation of an elected government. The new business rules are meant to bring clarity to some grey areas." The expansion of the L-G's powers in the appointment of the advocate-general and law officers leaves little leeway for the elected government, he points out. "The legislative assembly anyway was vested with little powers over the police and law and order as per the Reorganisation Act. By further empowering the L-G, it has ensured that the chief minister and the cabinet will be without any powers."

Section 55 of the 2019 Act, which governed the conduct of business, allowed the L-G to make rules on the 'advice of the council of ministers', and 'more convenient transaction of business with the ministers', while laying out the procedure to be adopted in case of a difference of opinion. But with J&K without a legislative assembly or an elected government, the Union government brought a proclamation on October 31, 2019, under which the